First, populists do not consider all IOs equal. Their ideology, which is deeply skeptical of elites and resistant to constraints on national sovereignty, predisposes populists to view certain IOs with particular antagonism. IOs that employ international, expert bureaucrats, have sprawling bureaucracies, and intrude deeply into domestic affairs are more likely to attract populist ire.

Institutions such as the EU, WTO, UN, NATO, IMF, and World Bank fit this profile. These organizations are often staffed by highly educated economists, lawyers, and bureaucrats, many of whom are Western-trained and whose policy preferences frequently diverge from those of populist leaders (Nelson 2017; Clark and Dolan 2021). In contrast, smaller regional IOs, which tend to have less stringent rules, more local staffing, and symbolic rather than enforcement-focused mandates, are less likely to provoke populist opposition. Regional financial arrangements, for example, offer small loans with significantly fewer strings than those of the IMF (Clark 2022). These smaller organizations often allow populists to opt out of initiatives and operate with limited enforcement mechanisms, making them less threatening and more accommodating.

Further, not all populist states pose equal threats to IOs. Powerful countries like the United States or the UK, when led by populist leaders, can significantly destabilize IOs. Their contributions to funding, staffing, and institutional legitimacy are critical, giving these states disproportionate influence. IOs are thus more likely to employ costly strategies when dealing with powerful populist states.

Smaller or less wealthy populist states, while less independently threatening, can still wield meaningful influence. They may strategically align with other populist states or exploit IO decision-making rules—such as unanimity requirements—to amplify their impact. In issue areas with negative externalities, such as trade or environmental compliance, even small states' defections can trigger cascading noncompliance, forcing IOs to act (Barrett 2003).

Our theory also carries strategy-specific scope conditions. When it comes to sidelining populist leaders, this strategy is most effective when IOs have alternative resources available to replace what populists might withhold. For instance, if a populist state cuts funding or refuses to provide critical data, IOs can mitigate the impact by seeking support from other